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Chicano Street Wear Fashion

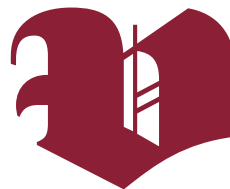
Issue One | Spring 2026

From Streets to Runways

How renowned designer
Willy Chavarria is changing
Chicano inspired fashion.



**WHERE EVERY PLACE HAS
A SCENT. AND EVERY
SCENT HAS A STORY.**



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Aguilar, Karina Solis, Sabrina Campos

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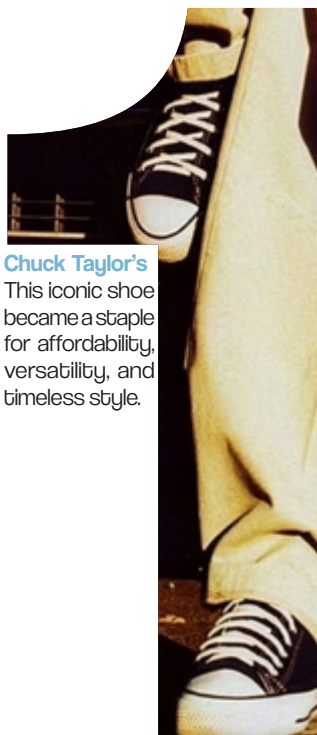
These are 5 pairs of shoes that are worn on the streets by Chicanos from family functions, in school hallways, and everywhere in between. Each pair tells a story of confidence, community, and cultural influence.

Words

Diego Rosiles-Camelo

Photos

Klaus Mitteldorf (1), Thaina Motta (2),
Houssem Boulifa (3), Hassan Prajin (4),
Renato Bezerra (5)



Chuck Taylor's

This iconic shoe became a staple for affordability, versatility, and timeless style.



Old Skool Vans

These became popular, typically worn by Chicana women because of their laid back California roots, and because it blended skate with everyday street wear.



Air Forces

These are iconic in Chicano street wear culture for its all white silhouette and timeless look, representing pride and a clean street wear aesthetic.



Huaraches

Huaraches have remained prominent in Chicano culture due to their connection to Mexican heritage and handcrafted design that blends culture and tradition.



Cortez's

This is the most iconic shoe in Chicano culture for their clean silhouette, deep ties to West Coast street style and gang life, symbolizing pride and identity.

ANATOMY OF THE ZOOT SUIT

Bright ties or wide knots brought extra character and completed the outfit with confidence.

Exaggerated shoulders created a bold silhouette that symbolized presence, pride, and resistance.

Wide legged pleated trousers gave the suit movement and a baggy look. Also shown is the long coat that turned every entrance into an event.

A swinging chain added shine, personality, and flair, proving style lives in the details.

Shiny shoes showed that presentation started from the ground up.



THE ZOOT SUIT: AN ALL-AMERICAN FASHION THAT CHANGED HISTORY

Words

Penn Today Authors

Photo

Katherine Bowers

With jacket arms that reached the fingertips and pants worn tight at the waist, it was nearly impossible to ignore someone wearing a zoot suit. At the dawn of World War II, the zoot suit was condemned by the U.S. government as wasteful. Not surprisingly, the criticism did little to dissuade its fans from wearing it.

"In the midst of the war it is associated with men who are criminals or members of gangs," Peiss explains. "Around 1943, there is a riot that breaks out in Los Angeles.

White servicemen and civilians begin to attack young men, especially Mexican-American men. They rip the clothing off their bodies, and the zoot suit takes on this sense of being a danger."

Though the zoot suit is largely gone, it is not forgotten. It reemerged in the late 1960s with the rise of the Chicano Rights Movement, and as a sort of retro fashion in the early 1990s with the revival of swing music and dance. ◇



FROM STREETS TO RUNWAYS

From the streets to the runway, Willy Chavarria re-imagines Chicano style, turning cultural identity into bold design, and proving that street wear can carry both history and power.

Words

Diego Rosiles-Camelo

Photos

IK Aldama, Adam Powell

Today's fashion trends often recycle themselves, while the cultural influences behind them are frequently overlooked or erased. Willy Chavarria stands apart as a designer who intentionally centers his work around Chicano and Mexican culture, bringing visibility to communities that have historically been underrepresented in high fashion. Through bold political statements, intentional model casting, oversized silhouettes inspired by Chicano street wear, and impactful storytelling, Chavarria has redefined what Chicano fashion looks like in the modern era. His designs blend luxury fashion with working-class influences, proving that cultural identity and street style deserve a place on the global runway. Rather than separating fashion from culture and activism, Chavarria uses clothing as a form of representation and resistance, elevating Chicano aesthetics to the global stage without losing their roots or authenticity.

Drawing inspiration from working-class communities, West Coast street wear, and his own upbringing, Chavarria transforms everyday staples into luxury fashion pieces with meaning behind them. Oversized silhouettes, tailored work wear, crisp white shirts, and monochromatic palettes all reflect styles deeply connected to Chicano identity and culture. Rather than treating these aesthetics as trends, Chavarria presents them as symbols of pride, resilience, and history. Continued on next page ➤



This campaign praises redefining street wear, embracing change, and finding your own unique style.

Join the cause on the website and help make a lasting impact.